

Overview: Task Analysis with Visual Checklist

Task analysis transforms overwhelming tasks into manageable sequences. You break a complex task into its component steps, create a visual checklist, and the pupil works through each step independently, ticking off as they go. This externalises the sequence from their working memory onto paper, dramatically reducing cognitive load and building independence.

When to Use This Strategy

- Pupil starts a task but stops partway through
- Completes some steps but misses others randomly
- Asks "what do I do next?" repeatedly
- Stares at the page, unsure how to continue

Step-by-Step Guide

1 Identify the task

Choose a task the pupil struggles to complete. It should have a clear start and end point.

Tip: Pick something they do regularly—the analysis becomes reusable.

2 Do the task yourself slowly

Actually do the task, step by step. Write down every single action, including ones that feel automatic to you.

Teacher says: "I'm going to do this myself and write down every step I take."

Tip: If your list has fewer than 6-8 steps for a complex task, you've probably missed some.

3 Add hidden cognitive steps

Review your list for invisible steps like "decide," "check," or "remember." These are often where breakdown happens.

Tip: Ask yourself: "What am I thinking between these two actions?"

4 Create the visual checklist

Write steps clearly with tick boxes. Use simple verb-led language: "Write," "Look at," "Pick up." Number each step.

Tip: Laminate for reuse. Add small pictures if helpful.

5 Teach the pupil to use it

Don't just hand over the checklist. Explicitly teach: "Point to step one. Do it. Tick it. Point to step two."

Teacher says: "This checklist shows you every step. Do one, tick it, move to the next. You don't need to remember what comes next—it's all here."

6 Fade your support

Initially stay close to prompt checklist use. Gradually move away as the pupil works independently through the steps.

Tip: The goal is the pupil using the checklist without you.

English Example: Writing a PEE paragraph

Year 9 writing about a character. Pupil knows the PEE structure but loses track of the sequence when writing.

Step 1: Create the checklist

Teacher: Writes checklist: 1. Write your point sentence. 2. Find a quote. 3. Write "This shows..." 4. Explain what the quote suggests. 5. Link back to the question. 6. Read through your paragraph.

Pupil: Receives laminated checklist with tick boxes.

Step 2: Teach checklist use

Teacher: Says: "Point to step one. What does it say? Good. Do that now. When you've done it, tick the box."

Pupil: Points to step one, reads it, writes point sentence, ticks box.

Step 3: Independent work

Teacher: Moves away. Only returns if pupil is stuck—then points to checklist: "Which step are you on?"

Pupil: Works through steps 2–6 independently, ticking each box. Completes paragraph.

Maths Example: Solving two-step equations

Year 8 solving equations like $2x + 5 = 13$. Pupil can do individual operations but loses track of the sequence.

Step 1: Create the checklist

Teacher: Writes checklist: 1. Circle the number on its own (+5). 2. Do the opposite to both sides. 3. Write the new equation. 4. Circle what's with x (2x). 5. Do the opposite to both sides. 6. Write x = answer. 7. Check by putting answer back in.

Pupil: Receives checklist with tick boxes.

Step 2: First problem together

Teacher: Says: "Step one—circle the number on its own. Which number? Good, +5. Tick. Step two—what's the opposite of +5?"

Pupil: Follows checklist step by step, ticking each box.

Step 3: Independent problems

Teacher: Sets three more equations. Says: "Use your checklist. Tick each step."

Pupil: Works through problems independently using checklist. Gets all three correct.

Science Example: Setting up a Bunsen burner

Year 7 practical. Pupil struggles to remember the safety sequence for lighting a Bunsen burner.

Step 1: Create visual checklist

Teacher: Creates checklist with pictures: 1. Put on safety goggles. 2. Check gas tap is off. 3. Connect rubber tube firmly. 4. Close the air hole. 5. Light the match. 6. Turn on gas tap. 7. Light the Bunsen. 8. Adjust air hole for blue flame.

Pupil: Receives laminated visual checklist to keep at workstation.

Step 2: Teach sequence

Teacher: Demonstrates while pointing to each step on checklist: "Watch me follow the checklist. Step one, goggles on. Tick."

Pupil: Watches and follows along on their own checklist.

Step 3: Pupil does it

Teacher: Says: "Your turn. Follow your checklist. Tick each step."

Pupil: Sets up Bunsen burner safely and independently, ticking off each step.